

# T H O U G H T S

U P O N

## S L A V E R Y.

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T H E F I F T H E D I T I O N .

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By *J O H N W E S L E Y*, A. M.

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L O N D O N :

Printed by G. P A R A M O R E, North Green, Worship-Street ;  
and sold by *G. Whitfield*, at the Chapel, City-Road ; and at the  
Methodist Preaching-Houses, in Town and Country. 1792.

[Price T W O P E N C E ,]

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UPON SLAVERY \*\*\*

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## I.

1. By *Slavery* I mean Domestic Slavery, or that of a servant to a master. A late ingenious Writer well observes, “The variety of forms in which Slavery appears, makes it almost impossible to convey a just notion of it, by way of definition. There are however certain properties which have accompanied Slavery in most places, whereby it is easily distinguished from that mild domestic *service* which obtains in our country.”<sup>[1]</sup>

<sup>[1]</sup> See Mr. *Hargrave*’s Plea for *Somerset* the Negro.

2. *Slavery* imports an obligation of perpetual service, an obligation which only the consent of the master can dissolve. Neither in some countries can the master himself dissolve it, without the consent of judges appointed by the law. It generally gives the master an arbitrary power of any correction, not affecting life or limb. Sometimes even these are exposed to his will: or protected only by a fine, or some slight punishment, too inconsiderable to restrain a master of a harsh temper. It creates an incapacity of acquiring any thing, except for the master’s benefit. It allows the master to alienate the Slave, in the same manner as his cows and horses. Lastly it descends in its full extent from parent to child, even to the last generation.

3. The beginning of this may be dated from the remotest period, of which we have an account in history. It commenced in the barbarous State of Society, and in process of time spread into all nations. It prevailed particularly among the *Jews*, the *Greeks*, the *Romans*, and the ancient *Germans*: and was transmitted by them to the various kingdoms and states, which arose out of the *Roman* empire. But after christianity prevailed, it gradually fell into decline in almost all parts of *Europe*. This great change began in *Spain*, about the end of the eighth century: and was become general in most other kingdoms of *Europe*, before the middle of the fourteenth.

4. From this time Slavery was nearly extinct, till the commencement of the sixteenth century, when the discovery of *America*, and of the Western and Eastern coasts of *Africa*, gave occasion to the revival of it. It took its rise from the *Portuguese*, who to supply the *Spaniards* with men, to cultivate their new possessions in *America*, procured Negroes from *Africa*, whom

they sold for Slaves to the *American Spaniards*. This began in the year 1508, when they imported the first Negroes into *Hispaniola*. In 1540, *Charles* the fifth, then King of *Spain*, determined to put an end to *Negro-Slavery*: giving positive orders, That all the Negro-Slaves in the *Spanish* dominions should be set free. And this was accordingly done by *Lagasca*, whom he sent and empowered to free them all, on condition of continuing to labour for their masters. But soon after *Lagasca* returned to *Spain*, Slavery returned and flourished as before. Afterwards other nations, as they acquired possessions in *America*, followed the examples of the *Spaniards*; and Slavery has taken deep root in most of our *American* colonies.

## II.

Such is the nature of Slavery: such the beginning of Negro-Slavery in *America*. But some may desire to know, what country it is, from which the Negroes are brought? What sort of men, of what temper and behaviour are they in their own country? And in what manner they are generally procured, carried to, and treated in *America*?

1. And first, What kind of country is that from whence they are brought? Is it so remarkably horrid, dreary and barren, that it is a kindness to deliver them out of it? I believe many have apprehended so: but it is an entire mistake, if we may give credit to those who have lived many years therein, and could have no motive to misrepresent it.

2. That part of *Africa* whence the Negroes are brought, commonly known by the name of *Guinea*, extends along the coast, in the whole, between three and four thousand miles. From the river *Senegal*, (seventeen degrees North of the line) to Cape *Sierra Leona*, it contains seven hundred miles. Thence it runs Eastward about fifteen hundred miles, including the *Grain-coast*, the *Ivory-coast*, the *Gold-coast*, and the *Slave-coast*, with the large kingdom of *Benin*. From thence it runs Southward, about twelve hundred miles, and contains the kingdoms of *Congo* and *Angola*.

3. Concerning the first, the *Senegal* coast, Mons. *Bene*, who lived there sixteen years, after describing its fruitfulness near the sea, says, "The farther you go from the sea, the more fruitful and well-improved is the country, abounding in pulse, Indian corn, and various fruits. Here are vast meadows, which feed large herds of great and small cattle. And the villages which lie thick, shew the country is well peopled." And again: "I was surprized, to see the land so well cultivated; scarce a spot lay unimproved: the low lands divided by small canals, were all sowed with rice: the higher grounds were planted with Indian corn, and peas of different sorts. Their beef is excellent; poultry plenty, and very cheap, as are all the necessaries of life."

4. As to the *Grain* and *Ivory-coast*, we learn from eye-witnesses, that the soil is in general fertile, producing abundance of rice and roots. Indigo and

cotton thrive without cultivation. Fish is in great plenty; the flocks and herds are numerous, and the trees loaden with fruit.

5. The *Gold-coast* and *Slave-coast*, all who have seen it agree, is exceeding fruitful and pleasant, producing vast quantities of rice and other grain, plenty of fruit and roots, palm-wine and oil, and fish in great abundance, with much tame and wild cattle. The very same account is given us of the soil and produce of the kingdoms of *Benin*, *Congo* and *Angola*. From which it appears, that *Guinea* in general, is far from a horrid, dreary, barren country, is one of the most fruitful, as well as the most pleasant countries in the known world. It is said indeed to be unhealthy. And so it is to strangers, but perfectly healthy to the native inhabitants.

6. Such is the country from which the Negroes are brought. We come next to enquire, What sort of men they are, of what temper and behaviour, not in our plantations, but in their native country. And here likewise the surest way is to take our account from eye and ear-witnesses. Now those who have lived in the *Senegal* country observe, it is inhabited by three nations, the *Jalofs*, *Fulis* and *Mandingos*. The king of the *Jalofs* has under him several Ministers, who assist in the exercise of justice, the Chief Justice goes in circuit through all his dominions, to hear complaints and determine controversies. And the Viceroy goes with him, to inspect the behaviour of the *Alkadi*, or Governor of each village. The *Fulis* are governed by their chief men, who rule with much moderation. Few of them will drink any thing stronger than water, being strict *Mahometans*. The government is easy, because the people are of a quiet and good disposition; and so well instructed in what is right, that a man who wrongs another is the abomination of all.—They desire no more land than they use, which they cultivate with great care and industry: if any of them are known to be made Slaves by the white men; they all join to redeem them. They not only support all that are old, or blind, or lame among themselves: but have frequently supplied the necessities of the *Mandingos*, when they were distressed by famine.

7. The *Mandingos*, says Mons. *Brue*, are right *Mahometans*, drinking neither wine nor brandy. They are industrious and laborious, keeping their ground well cultivated, and breeding a good stock of cattle. Every town has a Governor, and he appoints the labour of the people. The men work the ground designed for corn; the women and girls, the rice-ground. He

afterwards divides the corn and rice, among them: and decides all quarrels, if any arise. All the Mahometan Negroes constantly go to public prayers thrice a day: there being a Priest in every village, who regularly calls them together: and it is surprising to see the modesty, attention and reverence which they observe during their worship—These three nations practise several trades; they have Smiths, Sadlers, Potters and Weavers. And they are very ingenious at their several occupations. Their Smiths not only make all the instruments of iron, which they have occasion to use, but likewise work many things neatly in gold and silver. It is chiefly the women and children who weave fine cotton cloth, which they dye blue and black.

8. It was of these parts of *Guinea*, that Mons. *Adanson*, Correspondent of the Royal Academy of Sciences at *Paris*, from 1749, to 1753, gives the following account, both as to the country and people, “Which way soever I turned my eyes, I beheld a perfect image of pure nature: an agreeable solitude, bounded on every side by a charming landscape; the rural situation of cottages, in the midst of trees; the ease and quietness of the Negroes, reclined under the shade of the spreading foliage, with the simplicity of their dress and manners: the whole revived in my mind the idea of our first parents, and I seemed to contemplate the world in its primitive state. They are, generally speaking, very good natured, sociable and obliging. I was not a little pleased with my first reception, and it fully convinced me, that there ought to be a considerable abatement made, in the accounts we have of the savage character of the *Africans*.” He adds, “It is amazing that an illiterate people should reason so pertinently concerning the heavenly bodies. There is no doubt, but that with proper instruments, they would become excellent astronomers.”

9. The inhabitants of the *Grain* and *Ivory-coast* are represented by those that deal with them, as sensible, courteous, and the fairest traders on the coasts of *Guinea*. They rarely drink to excess: if any do they are severely punished by the King’s order. They are seldom troubled with war: if a difference happen between two nations, they commonly end the dispute amicably.

10. The inhabitants of the *Gold* and *Slave-coast* likewise, when they are not artfully incensed against each other, live in great union and friendship, being generally well tempered, civil, tractable, and ready to help any that need it. In particular, the natives of the kingdom of *Whidah*, are civil, kind,

and obliging to strangers. And they are the most gentleman-like of all the Negroes, abounding in good manners toward each other. The inferiors pay the utmost respect to their superiors: so wives to their husbands, children to their parents. And they are remarkably industrious; all are constantly employed; the men in agriculture, the women in spinning and weaving cotton.

11. The *Gold* and *Slave-coasts* are divided into several districts, some governed by Kings, others by the principal men, who take care each of their own town or village, and prevent or appease tumults. They punish murder and adultery severely; very frequently with death. Theft and robbery are punished by a fine proportionable to the goods that were taken.—All the natives of this coast, though heathens, believe there is one God, the Author of them and all things. They appear likewise to have a confused apprehension of a future state. And accordingly every town and village has a place of public worship.—It is remarkable that they have no beggars among them; such is the care of the chief men, in every city and village, to provide some easy labour, even for the old and weak. Some are employed in blowing the Smith's bellows; others in pressing palm-oil; others in grinding of colours. If they are too weak even for this, they sell provisions in the market.

12. The natives of the kingdom of *Benin* are a reasonable and good-natured people. They are sincere and inoffensive, and do no injustice either to one another or to strangers. They are eminently civil and courteous: if you make them a present, they endeavour to repay it double. And if they are trusted, till the ship returns the next year, they are sure honestly to pay the whole debt. Theft is punished among them, although not with the same severity as murder. If a man and woman of any quality, are taken in adultery, they are certain to be put to death, and their bodies thrown on a dunghill, and left a prey to wild beasts. They are punctually just and honest in their dealings; and are also very charitable: the King and the great Lords taking care to employ all that are capable of any work. And those that are utterly helpless they keep for God's sake; so that here also are no beggars. The inhabitants of *Congo* and *Angola* are generally a quiet people. They discover a good understanding, and behave in a friendly manner to strangers, being of a mild temper and an affable carriage.—Upon the whole therefore the Negroes who inhabit the coast of *Africa*, from the river *Senegal* to the

Southern bounds of *Angola*, are so far from being the stupid, senseless, brutish, lazy barbarians, the fierce, cruel, perfidious Savages they have been described, that on the contrary, they are represented by them who have no motive to flatter them, as remarkably sensible, considering the few advantages they have for improving their understanding: as industrious to the highest degree, perhaps more so than any other natives of so warm a climate: as fair, just and honest in all their dealings, unless where white men have taught them to be otherwise: and as far more mild, friendly and kind to strangers, than any of our forefathers were. Our forefathers! Where shall we find at this day, among the fair-faced natives of *Europe*, a nation generally practising the justice, mercy, and truth, which are found among these poor *Africans*? Suppose the preceding accounts are true, (which I see no reason or pretence to doubt of,) and we may leave *England* and *France*, to seek genuine honesty in *Benin*, *Congo*, or *Angola*.

### III.

We have now seen what kind of country it is, from which the Negroes are brought: and what sort of men (even white men being the judges) they were in their own country. Enquire we, thirdly, In what manner are they generally procured, carried to, and treated in *America*.

1. *First*. In what manner are they procured? Part of them by fraud. Captains of ships from time to time, invited Negroes to come on board, and then carried them away. But far more have been procured by force. The Christians landing upon their coasts, seized as many as they found, men, women and children, and transported them to *America*. It was about 1551, that the *English* began trading to *Guinea*: at first, for gold and Elephant's teeth, but soon after, for men. In 1556, Sir *John Hawkins* sailed with two ships to Cape *Verd*, where he sent eighty men on shore to catch Negroes. But the natives flying, they fell farther down, and there set the men on shore, "to burn their towns and take the inhabitants." But they met with such resistance, that they had seven men killed, and took but ten Negroes. So they went still farther down, till having taken enough, they proceeded to the *West-Indies* and sold them.

2. It was some time before the *Europeans* found a more compendious way of procuring *African* Slaves, by prevailing upon them to make war upon each other, and to sell their prisoners. Till then they seldom had any wars: but were in general quiet and peaceable. But the white men first taught them drunkenness and avarice, and then hired them to sell one another. Nay, by this means, even their Kings are induced to sell their own subjects. So Mr. *Moore* (Factor of the *African* Company in 1730) informs us, "When the King of *Barsalli* wants goods or brandy, he sends to the *English* Governor at *James' Fort*, who immediately sends a sloop. Against the time it arrives, he plunders some of his neighbours' towns, selling the people for the goods he wants. At other times he falls upon one of his own towns, and makes bold to sell his own subjects." So Mons. *Brue* says, "I wrote to the King" (not the same) "if he had a sufficient number of slaves I would treat with him. He seized three hundred of his own people, and sent word he was ready to deliver them for goods." He adds, "Some of the natives are always ready" (when well paid) "to surprize and carry off their own countrymen.

They come at night without noise, and if they find any lone cottage, surround it and carry off all the people.”—*Barbot*, (another French Factor) says, “Many of the Slaves sold by the Negroes are prisoners of war, or taken in the incursions they make into their enemy’s territories. Others are stolen. Abundance of little Blacks of both sexes, are stolen away by their neighbours, when found abroad on the road, or in the woods, or else in the corn-fields, at the time of year when their parents keep them there all day to scare away the devouring birds.” That their own parents sell them, is utterly false: Whites not Blacks, are without natural affection!

3. To set the manner wherein Negroes are procured in a yet stronger light, it will suffice to give an extract of two voyages to *Guinea* on this account. The first is taken verbatim from the original manuscript of the Surgeon’s Journal.

“SESTRO, Dec. 29, 1724. No trade to-day, though many traders came on board. They informed us, that the people are gone to war within land, and will bring prisoners enough in two or three days; in hopes of which we stay.

“The 30th. No trade yet: but our traders came on board to-day, and informed us the people had burnt four towns: so that to-morrow we expect slaves off.

“The 31st, Fair weather; but no trading yet. We see each night towns burning. But we hear many of the *Sestro* men are killed by the inland Negroes: so that we fear this war will be unsuccessful.

“The second of January. Last night we saw a prodigious fire break out about eleven o’clock, and this morning see the town of *Sestro* burnt down to the ground.” (It contained some hundred houses.) “So that we find their enemies are too hard for them at present, and consequently our trade spoiled here. Therefore about seven o’clock we weighed anchor, to proceed lower down.”

4. The second Extract taken from the Journal of a Surgeon, who went from *New-York* on the same trade, is as follows. “The Commander of the vessel sent to acquaint the King, that he wanted a cargo of slaves. The King promised to furnish him, and in order to it, set out, designing to surprize some town, and make all the people prisoners. Some time after, the King sent him word, he had not yet met with the desired success: having

attempted to break up two towns, but having been twice repulsed: but that he still hoped to procure the number of Slaves. In this design he persisted, till he met his enemies in the field. A battle was fought, which lasted three days. And the engagement was so bloody, that four thousand five hundred men were slain upon the spot.”——Such is the manner wherein the Negroes are procured! Thus the Christians preach the Gospel to the Heathens!

5. Thus they are *procured*. But in what numbers and in what manner are they carried to *America*?——Mr. *Anderson* in his history of Trade and Commerce, observes, “*England* supplies her *American* Colonies with Negro-slaves, amounting in number to about a hundred thousand every year.” That is, so many are taken on board our ships; but at least ten thousand of them die in the voyage: about a fourth part more die at the different Islands, in what is called the Seasoning. So that at an average, in the passage and seasoning together, thirty thousand die: that is, properly are murdered. O earth, O sea, cover not thou their blood!

6. When they are brought down to the shore in order to be sold, our Surgeons thoroughly examine them, and that quite naked, women and men, without any distinction: those that are approved are set on one side. In the mean time a burning iron, with the arms or name of the Company, lies in the fire, with which they are marked on the breast. Before they are put into the ships, their masters strip them of all they have on their backs: so that they come on board stark naked, women as well as men. It is common for several hundred of them to be put on board one vessel: where they are stowed together in as little room as it is possible for them to be crowded. It is easy to suppose what a condition they must soon be in, between heat, thirst and stench of various kinds. So that it is no wonder, so many should die in the passage; but rather that any survive it.

7. When the vessels arrive at their destined port, the Negroes are again exposed naked, to the eyes of all that flock together, and the examination of their purchasers; then they are separated to the plantations of their several masters, to see each other no more. Here you may see mothers hanging over their daughters, bedewing their naked breasts with tears, and daughters clinging to their parents, till the whipper soon obliges them to part. And what can be more wretched than the condition they then enter upon? Banished from their country, from their friends and relations for ever, from

every comfort of life, they are reduced to a state scarce any way preferable to that of beasts of burden. In general a few roots, not of the nicest kind, usually yams or potatoes, are their food, and two rags, that neither screen them from the heat of the day, nor the cold of the night their covering. Their sleep is very short, their labour continual, and frequently above their strength; so that death sets many of them at liberty, before they have lived out half their days. The time they work in the *West-Indies*, is from day-break to noon, and from two o'clock till dark: during which time they are attended by overseers, who, if they think them dilatory, or think any thing not so well done as it should be, whip them most unmercifully, so that you may see their bodies long after whealed and scarred usually from the shoulders to the waist. And before they are suffered to go to their quarters, they have commonly something to do, as collecting herbage for the horses, or gathering fewel for the boilers. So that it is often past twelve before they can get home. Hence if their food is not prepared, they are some times called to labour again, before they can satisfy their hunger. And no excuse will avail. If they are not in the field immediately, they must expect to feel the lash. Did the Creator intend that the noblest creatures in the visible world, should live such a life as this! “Are *these* thy glorious works, Parent of Good?”

8. As to the punishment inflicted on them, says Sir *Hans Sloan*, “they frequently geld them, or chop off half a foot: after they are whipped till they are raw all over. Some put pepper and salt upon them: some drop melted wax upon their skin. Others cut off their ears, and constrain them to broil and eat them. For Rebellion,” (that is, asserting their native Liberty, which they have as much right to as to the air they breathe) “they fasten them down to the ground with crooked sticks on every limb, and then applying fire by degrees, to the feet and hands, they burn them gradually upward to the head.”

9. But will not the laws made in the plantations, prevent or redress all cruelty and oppression? We will take but a few of those laws for a specimen, and then let any man judge.

In order to rivet the chain of slavery, the law of *Virginia* ordains, “That no slave shall be set free, upon any pretence whatever, except for some meritorious services, to be adjudged and allowed by the *Governor and Council*: and that where any slave shall be set free by his owner, otherwise

than is herein directed, the Church-wardens of the parish wherein such negro shall reside for the space of one month are hereby authorized and required, to *take up and sell* the said negro, by *public outcry*.”

10. Will not these Law-givers take effectual care, to prevent cruelty and oppression?

The law of *Jamaica* ordains, “Every slave that shall run away, and continue absent from his master twelve months, shall be *deemed rebellious*.” And by another law, fifty pounds are allowed, to those who kill or bring in alive a *rebellious* slave. So their law treats these poor men with as little ceremony and consideration, as if they were merely brute beasts! But the innocent blood which is shed in consequence of such a detestable law, must call for vengeance on the murderous abettors and actors of such deliberate wickedness.

11. But the law of *Barbadoes* exceeds even this, “If any negro under punishment, by his master, or his order, for running away, or any other crime or misdemeanor, shall suffer *in life or member, no person whatsoever shall be liable to any fine therefore*. But if any man, of wantonness, or only of bloody-mindedness or cruel intention, *wilfully kill* a negro of his own” (Now observe the severe punishment!) “He shall pay into the public treasury fifteen pounds sterling! And not be liable to any other punishment or forfeiture for the same!”

Nearly allied to this is that law of *Virginia*: “After proclamation is issued against slaves that run away, it is lawful for any person whatsoever to kill and destroy such slaves, by such ways and means as he shall think fit.”

We have seen already some of the ways and means which have been *thought fit* on such occasions. And many more might be mentioned. One Gentleman, when I was abroad, *thought fit* to roast his slave alive! But if the most natural act of “running away” from intolerable tyranny, deserves such relentless severity, what punishment have these *Law-makers* to expect hereafter, on account of their own enormous offences?

#### IV.

1. This is the plain, unaggravated matter of fact. Such is the manner wherein our *African* slaves are procured: such the manner wherein they are removed from their native land, and wherein they are treated in our plantations. I would now enquire, whether these things can be defended, on the principles of even heathen honesty? Whether they can be reconciled (setting the Bible out of the question) with any degree of either justice or mercy?

2. The grand plea is, “They are authorized by law.” But can law, Human Law, change the nature of things? Can it turn darkness into light, or evil into good? By no means. Notwithstanding ten thousand laws, right is right, and wrong is wrong still. There must still remain an essential difference between justice and injustice, cruelty and mercy. So that I still ask, who can reconcile this treatment of the negroes, first and last, with either mercy or justice?

Where is the justice of inflicting the severest evils, on those that have done us no wrong? Of depriving those that never injured us in word or deed, of every comfort of life? Of tearing them from their native country, and depriving them of liberty itself? To which an *Angolan*, has the same natural right as an *Englishman*, and on which he sets as high a value? Yea, where is the justice of taking away the lives of innocent, inoffensive men? Murdering thousands of them in their own land, by the hands of their own countrymen: many thousands, year after year, on shipboard, and then casting them like dung into the sea! And tens of thousands in that cruel slavery, to which they are so unjustly reduced?

3. But waving, for the present, all other considerations, I strike at the root of this complicated villany. I absolutely deny all slave-holding to be consistent with any degree of natural justice.

I cannot place this in a clearer light, than that great ornament of his profession, Judge *Blackstone* has already done. Part of his words are as follows:

“The three origins of the right of slavery assigned by *Justinian*, are all built upon false foundations. 1. Slavery is said to arise from captivity in war. The conqueror having a right to the life of his captive, if he spares that, has then

a right to deal with them as he speaks. But this is untrue, if taken generally, That by the laws of nations, a man has a right to kill his enemy. He has only a right to kill him in particular cases, in cases of absolute necessity for self-defence. And it is plain, this absolute necessity did not subsist, since he did not kill him, but made him prisoner. War itself is justifiable only on principles of self-preservation. Therefore it gives us no right over prisoners, but to hinder their hurting us by confining them. Much less can it give a right to torture, or kill, or even enslave an enemy when the war is over. Since therefore the right of making our prisoners slaves, depends on a supposed right of slaughter, that foundation failing, the consequence which is drawn from it must fail likewise.”

“It is said secondly, Slavery may begin, by one man’s selling himself to another. And it is true, a man may sell himself to work for another; but he can not sell himself to be a slave, as above defined. Every sale implies an equivalent given to the seller, in lieu of what he transfers to the buyer. But what equivalent can be given for life or liberty? His property likewise, with the very price which he seems to receive, devolves *ipso facto* to his master, the instant he becomes his slave: in this case therefore the buyer gives nothing. Of what validity then can a sale be, which destroys the very principle upon which all sales are founded?”

“We are told, Thirdly, that men may be *born slaves*, by being the children of slaves. But this being built upon the two former rights must fall together with them, if neither captivity, nor contract can by the plain law of nature and reason, reduce the parent to a state of slavery, much less can they reduce the offspring.” It clearly follows, that all slavery is as irreconcilable to justice as to mercy.

4. That slave-holding is utterly inconsistent with mercy, is almost too plain to need a proof. Indeed it is said, “That these negroes being prisoners of war, our captains and factors buy them, merely to save them from being put to death. And is not this mercy?” I answer, 1. Did Sir *John Hawkins*, and many others, seize upon men, women and children, who were at peace in their own fields and houses, merely to save them from death? 2. Was it to save them from death, that they knock’d out the brains of those they could not bring away? 3. Who occasioned and fomented those wars, wherein these poor creatures were taken prisoners? Who excited them by money, by drink, by every possible means, to fall upon one another? Was it not

themselves? They know in their own conscience it was, if they have any conscience left. But 4. To bring the matter to a short issue. Can they say before God, That they ever took a single voyage, or bought a single negro from this motive? They cannot, they well know, to get money, not to save lives, was the whole and sole spring of their motions.

5. But if this manner of procuring and tearing negroes is not consistent either with mercy or justice, yet there is a plea for it which every man of business will acknowledge to be quite sufficient. Fifty years ago, one meeting an eminent statesman in the lobby of the House of Commons, said, “You have been long talking about justice and equity, Pray which is this bill? Equity or justice?” He answered, very short, and plain, “D—n justice: it is necessity.” Here also the slave-holder fixes his foot: here he rests the strength of his cause. “If it is not quite right, yet it *must* be so: there is an absolute *necessity for it*. It is necessary we should procure slaves: and when we have procured them, it is necessary to use them with severity, considering their stupidity, stubbornness and wickedness.”

I answer, You stumble at the threshold: I deny that villany is ever necessary. It is impossible that it should ever be necessary, for any reasonable creature to violate all the laws of justice, mercy, and truth. No circumstances can make it necessary for a man to burst in sunder all the ties of humanity. It can never be necessary for a rational being to sink himself below a brute. A man can be under no necessity, of degrading himself into a wolf. The absurdity of the supposition is so glaring, that one would wonder any one could help seeing it.

6. This in general. But to be more particular, I ask, 1. What is necessary? And secondly, To what end? It may be answered, “The whole method now used by the original purchasers of negroes, is necessary to the furnishing our colonies yearly with a hundred thousand slaves.” I grant this is necessary to that end. But how is that end necessary? How will you prove it necessary that one hundred, that *one* of those slaves should be procured? “Why, it is necessary to my gaining an hundred thousand pounds.” Perhaps so: but how is *this* necessary? It is very possible you might be both a better and a happier man, if you had not a quarter of it. I deny that your gaining one thousand is necessary, either to your present or eternal happiness. “But however you must allow, these slaves are necessary for the cultivation of our Islands: inasmuch as white men are not able to labour in hot climates.” I

answer, 1. It were better that all those Islands should remain uncultivated for ever, yea, it were more desirable that they were altogether sunk in the depth of the sea, than that they should be cultivated at so high a price, as the violation of justice, mercy and truth. But, secondly, the supposition on which you ground your argument is false. For white men, even *English* men, are well able to labour in hot climates: provided they are temperate both in meat and drink, and that they inure themselves to it by degrees. I speak no more than I know by experience. It appears from the thermometer, that the summer heat in *Georgia*, is frequently equal to that in *Barbadoes*, yea to that under the line. And yet I and my family (eight in number) did employ all our spare time there, in felling of trees and clearing of ground, as hard labour as any negro need be employed in. The *German* family likewise, forty in number, were employed in all manner of labour. And this was so far from impairing our health, that we all continued perfectly well, while the idle ones round about us, were swept away as with a pestilence. It is not true therefore that white men are not able to labour, even in hot climates, full as well as black. But if they were not, it would be better that none should labour there, that the work should be left undone, than that myriads of innocent men should be murdered, and myriads more dragged into the basest slavery.

7. “But the furnishing us with slaves is necessary, for the trade, and wealth, and glory of our nation:” here are several mistakes. For 1. Wealth is not necessary to the glory of any nation; but wisdom, virtue, justice, mercy, generosity, public spirit, love of our country. These are necessary to the real glory of a nation; but abundance of wealth is not. Men of understanding allow, that the glory of *England* was full as high, in Queen *Elizabeth*’s time as it is now: although our riches and trade were then as much smaller, as our virtue was greater. But, secondly, it is not clear, that we should have either less money or trade, (only less of that detestable trade of man-stealing) if there was not a negro in all our Islands, or in all *English America*. It is demonstrable, white men, inured to it by degrees *can* work as well as them: and they *would* do it, were negroes out of the way, and proper encouragement given them. However, thirdly, I come back to the same point: better no trade, than trade procured by villany. It is far better to have no wealth, than to gain wealth at the expence of virtue. Better is honest poverty, than all the riches bought by the tears, and sweat and blood of our fellow-creatures.

8. “However this be; it is necessary when we have slaves, to use them with severity.” What, to whip them for every petty offence, till they are all in gore blood? To take that opportunity, of rubbing pepper and salt into their raw flesh? To drop burning sealing-wax upon their skin? To castrate them? To cut off half their foot with an axe? To hang them on gibbets, that they may die by inches, with heat, and hunger, and thirst? To pin them down to the ground, and then burn them by degrees, from the feet, to the head? To roast them alive?—When did a Turk or a Heathen find it necessary to use a fellow-creature thus?

I pray, to what end is this usage necessary? “Why, to prevent their running away: and to keep them constantly to their labour, that they may not idle away their time. So miserably stupid is this race of men, yea, so stubborn and so wicked.” Allowing them to be as stupid as you say, to whom is that stupidity owing? Without question it lies altogether at the door of their inhuman masters: who give them no means, no opportunity of improving their understanding: and indeed leave them no motive, either from hope or fear, to attempt any such thing. They were no way remarkable for stupidity, while they remained in their own country: the inhabitants of *Africa* where they have equal motives and equal means of improvement, are not inferior to the inhabitants of *Europe*: to some of them they are greatly superior. Impartially survey in their own country, the natives of *Benin*, and the natives of *Lapland*. Compare, (setting prejudice aside) the *Samoeids* and the *Angolans*. And on which side does the advantage lie, in point of understanding? Certainly the *African* is in no respect inferior to the *European*. Their stupidity therefore in our plantations is not natural; otherwise than it is the natural effect of their condition. Consequently it is not their fault, but *your*’s: you must answer for it, before God and man.

9. “But their stupidity is not the only reason of our treating them with severity. For it is hard to say, which is the greatest, this or their stubbornness and wickedness.”——It may be so: But do not these as well as the other, lie at *your* door; are not stubbornness, cunning, pilfering, and divers other vices, the natural, necessary fruits of slavery? Is not this an observation which has been made, in every age and nation?——And what means have you used to remove this stubbornness? Have you tried what mildness and gentleness would do? I knew one that did: that had prudence and patience to make the experiment: Mr. *Hugh Bryan*, who then lived on

the borders of *South-Carolina*. And what was the effect? Why, that all his negroes (and he had no small number of them) loved and revered him as a father, and cheerfully obeyed him out of love. Yea, they were more afraid of a frown from *him*, than of many blows from an overseer. And what pains have *you* taken, what method have *you* used, to reclaim them from their wickedness? Have you carefully taught them,

“That there is a God, a wise, powerful, merciful being, the Creator and Governor of heaven and earth? That he has appointed a day wherein he will judge the world, will take an account of all our thoughts, words and actions? That in that day he will reward every child of man according to his works: that “then the righteous shall inherit the kingdom prepared for them from the foundation of the world: and the wicked shall be cast into everlasting fire, prepared for the devil and his angels.” If you have not done this, if you have taken no pains or thought about the matter, can you wonder at their wickedness? What wonder, if they should cut your throat? And if they did, whom could you thank for it but yourself? You first acted the villain in making them slaves, (whether you stole them or bought them.) You kept them stupid and wicked, by cutting them off from all opportunities of improving either in knowledge or virtue: and now you assign their want of wisdom and goodness as the reason for using them worse than brute beasts!

## V.

1. It remains only to make a little application of the preceding observations.—But to whom should that application be made? That may bear a question. Should we address ourselves to the public at large? What effect can this have? It may inflame the world against the guilty, but is not likely to remove that guilt. Should we appeal to the *English* nation in general? This also is striking wide; and is never likely to procure any redress for the sore evil we complain of.—As little would it in all probability avail, to apply to the Parliament. So many things, which *seem* of greater importance lie before them that they are not likely to attend to this. I therefore add a few words to those who are more immediately concerned, whether captains, merchants or planters.

2. And, first, to the captains employed in this trade. Most of *you* know, the country of *Guinea*: several parts of it at least, between the river *Senegal* and the kingdom of *Angola*. Perhaps now, by *your* means, part of it is become a dreary uncultivated wilderness, the inhabitants being all murdered or carried away, so that there are none left to till the ground. But you well know, how populous, how fruitful, how pleasant it was a few years ago. You know the people were not stupid, not wanting in sense, considering the few means of improvement they enjoyed. Neither did you find them savage, fierce, cruel, treacherous, or unkind to strangers. On the contrary, they were in most parts, a sensible and ingenious people. They were kind and friendly, courteous and obliging, and remarkably fair and just in their dealings. Such are the men whom you hire their own countrymen, to tear away from this lovely country; part by stealth, part by force, part made captive in those wars, which you raise or foment on purpose. You have seen them torn away, children from their parents, parents from their children: husbands from their wives, wives from their beloved husbands, brethren and sisters from each other. You have dragged them who had never done you any wrong, perhaps in chains, from their native shore. You have forced them into your ships like an herd of swine, them who had souls immortal as your own: (only some of them, leaped into the sea, and resolutely stayed under water, till they could suffer no more from you.) You have stowed them together as close as ever they could lie, without any regard either to decency or convenience. And

when many of them had been poisoned by foul air, or had sunk under various hardships, you have seen their remains delivered to the deep, till the sea should give up its dead. You have carried the survivors into the vilest slavery, never to end but with life: such slavery as is not found among the Turks at *Algiers*, no nor among the Heathens in *America*.

3. May I speak plainly to you? I must. Love constrains me: love to *you*, as well as to those you are concerned with.

Is there a God? You know there is. Is he a just God? Then there must be a state of retribution: a state wherein the just God will reward every man according to his works. Then what reward will he render to *you*? O think betimes! Before you drop into eternity! Think now, *He shall have judgment without mercy that hath shewed no mercy*. Are you a *man*? Then you should have a *human* heart. But have you indeed? What is your heart made of? Is there no such principle as compassion there? Do you never *feel* another's pain? Have you no sympathy? No sense of human woe? No pity for the miserable? When you saw the flourishing eyes, the heaving breasts, or the bleeding sides and tortured limbs of your fellow-creatures, was you a stone, or a brute? Did you look upon them with the eyes of a tiger? When you squeezed the agonizing creatures down in the ship, or when you threw their poor mangled remains into the sea, had you no relenting? Did not one tear drop from your eye, one sigh escape from your breast? Do you feel no relenting *now*? If you do not, you must go on, till the measure of your iniquities is full. Then will the great God deal with *you*, as you have dealt with *them*, and require all their blood at your hands. And at that day it shall be more tolerable for Sodom and Gomorrah than for *you*! But if your heart does relent, though in a small degree, know it is a call from the God of love. And to-day, if you will hear his voice, harden not your heart. To-day resolve, God being your helper, to escape for your life. Regard not money! All that a man hath will he give for his life! Whatever you lose, lose not your soul: nothing can countervail that loss. Immediately quit the horrid trade: at all events, be an honest man.

4. This equally concerns every Merchant, who is engaged in the Slave-trade. It is *you* that induce the *African* villain to sell his countrymen; and in order thereto, to steal, rob, murder men, women and children without number: by enabling the *English* villain to pay him for so doing; whom you over pay for his execrable labour. It is *your* money, that is the spring of all,

that impowers him to go on: so that whatever he or the *African* does in this matter, is all *your* act and deed. And is your conscience quite reconciled to this? Does it never reproach you at all? Has gold entirely blinded your eyes, and stupified your heart? Can you see, can you *feel* no harm therein? Is it doing as you would be done to? Make the case your own. “Master,” said a Slave at *Liverpool* (to the Merchant that owned him) “what if some of my countrymen were to come here, and take away my mistress, and master *Tommy* and master *Billy* and carry them into our country, and make them slaves, how would you like it?” His answer was worthy of a man: “I will never buy a slave more while I live.” O let his resolution be your’s! Have no more any part in this detestable business. Instantly leave it to those unfeeling wretches, “Who laugh at human nature and compassion!” Be *you* a man! Not a wolf, a devourer of the human species! Be merciful, that you may obtain mercy!

5. And this equally concerns every gentleman that has an estate in our *American* plantations: yea all Slave-holders of whatever rank and degree: seeing *men-buyers* are exactly on a level with *men-stealers*. Indeed you say, “I pay honestly for my goods: and I am not concerned to know how they are come by”: nay but you are: you are deeply concerned to know they are honestly come by. Otherwise you are partaker with a thief, and are not a jot honestest than him. But you know, they are not honestly come by: you know they are procured by means, nothing near so innocent as picking pockets, house-breaking, or robbery upon the high-way. You know they are procured by a deliberate series of more complicated villany, (of fraud, robbery and murder) than was ever practised either by Mahometans or Pagans: in particular by murders of all kinds; by the blood of the innocent poured upon the ground like water. Now it is *your* money that pays the Merchant, and through him the Captain, and the *African* butchers. *You* therefore are guilty, yea principally guilty, of all these frauds, robberies and murders. You are the spring that puts all the rest in motion: they would not stir a step without *you*: therefore the blood of all these wretches, who die before their time, whether in the country or elsewhere, lies upon your head. *The blood of thy brother*, (for, whether thou wilt believe it or no, such he is in the sight of Him that made him) *crieth against thee from the earth*, from the ship, and from the waters. O, whatever it costs, put a stop to its cry before it be too late: instantly, at any price, were it the half of your goods, deliver thyself from blood-guiltiness! Thy hands, thy bed, thy furniture, thy house, thy

lands are at present stained with blood. Surely it is enough; accumulate no more guilt: spill no more the blood of the innocent! Do not hire another to shed blood: do not pay him for doing it! Whether you are a Christian or no, shew yourself a man! Be not more savage than a lion or a bear!

6. Perhaps you will say, “I do not *buy* any Negroes: I only *use* those left by my father.” So far is well: but is it enough to satisfy your own conscience? Had your father, have *you*, has any man living, a right to use another as a slave? It cannot be, even setting revelation aside. It cannot be that either war, or contract, can give any man such a property in another as he has in his sheep and oxen. Much less is it possible, that any child of man, should ever be *born a slave*. Liberty is the right of every human creature, as soon as he breathes the vital air. And no human law can deprive him of that right, which he derives from the law of nature.

If therefore you have any regard to justice, (to say nothing of mercy, nor the revealed law of God) render unto all their due. Give liberty to whom liberty is due, that is to every child of man, to every partaker of human nature. Let none serve you but by his own act and deed, by his own voluntary choice. Away with all whips, all chains, all compulsion! Be gentle toward all men, and see that you invariably do unto every one, as you would he should do unto *you*.

7. O thou God of love, thou who art loving to every man, and whose mercy is over all thy works; thou who art the Father of the spirits of all flesh, and who art rich in mercy unto all; thou who has mingled of one blood, all the nations upon the earth; have compassion upon these outcasts of men, who are trodden down as dung upon the earth! Arise and help these that have no helper, whose blood is spilt upon the ground like water! Are not these also the work of thine own hands, the purchase of thy Son’s blood? Stir them up to cry unto thee in the land of their captivity; and let their complaint come up before thee; let it enter into thy ears! Make even those that lead them away captive to pity them, and turn their captivity as the rivers in the South. O burst thou all their chains in sunder; more especially the chains of their sins: Thou, Saviour of all, make them free, that they may be free indeed!

The servile progeny of *Ham*  
Seize as the purchase of thy blood!  
Let all the Heathens know thy name,

From Idols to the living God;  
The dark *Americans* convert,  
And shine in every Pagan heart.

**FINIS**

**Transcriber's Note**

Clear printer's errors have been corrected by the transcriber; as far as possible, however, original spelling and punctuation have been preserved.

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